

BLACK-WINGED KITE

Elanus caeruleus

Habitat: Plains and high altitudes in Sikkim, Nagaland and the Nilgiris

Reason for decline: Pesticides

MOD



HIGH

RAPTORS' FALL

TREND: Birds of prey, particularly those in open habitat or forests/ plantations, have showed an annual declining trend of around 50 per cent between 2014 and 2022. While the Pallid harrier has declined by nearly 70 per cent, the Short-toed snake eagle and Western marsh harrier also show decline between 50 and 70 per cent.

WHY: Open-habitat raptors typically feed in farming landscapes, where pesticide is used. Carrion-feeding vultures, specifically, succumbed to livestock drug diclofenac, which gave them kidney issues. Its ban may have improved things, but vultures continue to decline in the country—the Indian vulture by over 8 per cent a year, the Red-headed and White-rumped vultures by over 5 and 4 per cent, respectively. The Egyptian vulture fares only slightly better.



"If birds can't survive, it won't be long before humans too will find it hard to survive. Birds like sparrows are indicator species that reflect the ecosystem health"

– KARTICK SATYANARAYAN

CEO and co-founder, Wildlife SOS

currently listed as a species of 'Least Concern' in the IUCN red list. In fact, about 51 per cent of the species in SoIB's high priority list are classified as of least concern globally in the IUCN list. On the other hand, 14 species considered globally endangered, vulnerable, or near-threatened are classified low priority in the SoIB assessment. For instance, the Jerdon's courser (*Rhinoptilus bitorquatus*), a delicate and lapwing-like nocturnal bird found